texts, though in this respect the *Ashokavadana* is an exception because it does specify her birthplace: it describes her as the beautiful daughter of a Brahman from Champa.[23] If so, the maternal origins of Ashoka lie in an ancient city of some fame, an urban settlement not at too great a distance from Pataliputra. Like the Magadhan capital, Champa was in its day an imposingly fortified city surrounded by a moat, not far from the Ganga.[24] Its ruins still grace a high square plateau that can be seen on the outskirts of modern Bhagalpur in Bihar.[25]

But coming back to the reiteration of the original prediction: as the story goes, Champa's citizen, this daughter of a Brahman, came to marry a king, the Maurya emperor Bindusara, because such an event had been foretold to her father. Once more, the coming is presaged, this time by an anonymous someone or some people connected with the future king's mother. This too is a narrative archetype common in Indian religious and hagiographical texts as much as in Middle Eastern and European, the classic example being Mary's dream in which the Angel Gabriel tells her she will bear a king, the future Jesus. An instance of a trope where ambitious kinsmen of a prince's mother find special mention exists also in the *Arthashastra*. Possibly for this reason they are seen as posing a threat to the king by being in league with the princes.[26]

Unlike the prophecy by the Buddha, where the persona of the predictor endows his words with a religious aura, the diviners in this episode happen to be anonymous. Neither their names nor their social station are mentioned. They are merely people who inform the Brahman that his daughter will be betrothed to a king. Simultaneously, they prophesy the destiny of the sons she will bear, one of whom, according to the soothsayers, will become the emperor. As the passage puts it: 'The fortune tellers predicted she would marry a king and bear two jewel-like sons: one would become a cakravartin ruling over one of the four continents, the other would wander forth and fulfil his religious vows.'[27]